card on a new site, but more than half have done it somewhere they trust.

The catch is that the risk doesn't sit with the store alone. A saved card is only as safe as the account protecting it, which brings us to passwords.

Passwords

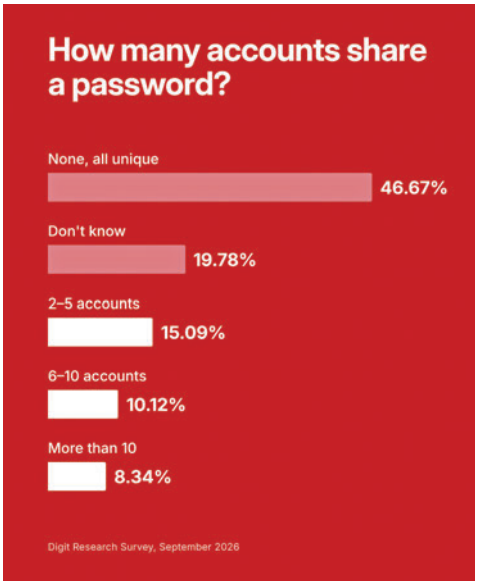
We asked readers how many of their accounts across apps and websites share the same password. About 47 percent said every account has a unique password, the largest single group and a genuinely healthy sign.

The rest of the picture is less comforting. Around 15 percent reuse the same password across 2–5 accounts, 10 percent across 6–10 accounts, and 8 percent across more than 10. Taken together, roughly a third of readers are reusing passwords. One leaked password unlocks many doors at once.

The most telling number is the 20 percent who said they don't know. If you can't say how many of your accounts share a password, it's safe to assume the answer isn't zero. A password manager would sort out both problems for most of these readers.

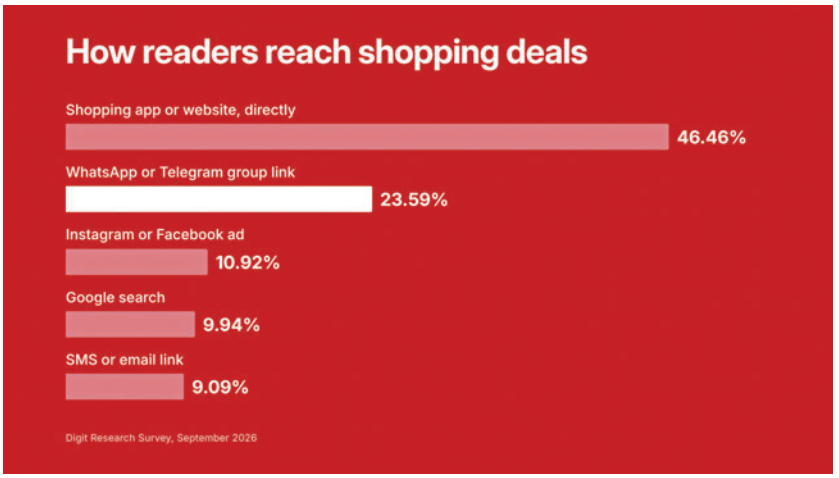
Two-Factor Authentication

Two-factor authentication (2FA) is the simplest upgrade people can make to their account security, so we asked readers where they have turned it on. Readers could pick more than one option, so these numbers are shares of responses, not individual readers.



Email leads comfortably at nearly 38 percent, which makes sense since the inbox is the master key to every password reset. Banking and UPI apps came in at about 16 percent, possibly because many of these apps already ask for an OTP or PIN by default. Shopping apps followed at 11 percent and social media at 9 percent.

Then there's the worrying bit. About 17 percent of responses came from readers who aren't sure what 2FA is, and another 9 percent said they haven't turned it on anywhere. That's over a quarter of responses where 2FA is either not understood or not being used, a gap scammers are more than happy to exploit.



Spotting scams

How confident are readers that they can spot a fake shopping website or a scam message? Fairly confident, it turns out. Around 34 percent said they are very confident and another 22 percent said they are somewhat confident, so over half back themselves.

On the other side, about 15 percent said they are not at all confident and 7 percent said they're not very confident, roughly one in five in total. Another 12 percent sat on the fence. A smaller pool of readers answered this question, so treat it as a signal rather than the final word.

Confidence is a good thing, but it can also be a blind spot. Today's fake stores copy logos, product photos and even checkout pages, and the scams that work best are the ones that don't look like scams at all.

In summary

Our September survey paints a picture of a careful but inconsistent online shopper. At the checkout, Indian readers are cautious. Nearly half fall back on cash on delivery when trying a new site, and very few would trust an unfamiliar platform with a saved card.

The weak spots sit before and after that moment. Close to 44 percent of deal-hunting responses begin with someone else's link, a third of readers reuse passwords, and over a quarter of 2FA responses point to readers who either don't use it or don't know what it is. Meanwhile, the scams that actually catch people are mundane, led by fake delivery-fee messages.

This festive season, the lesson is simple. Go to the app directly, keep unique passwords, switch on 2FA wherever offered, and treat any message asking for a "small fee" with suspicion. The biggest risk isn't the payment page. It's the link that gets you there.